

STAGE EIGHT • SOFT SKILLS

FIRSTS

SESSION PLAN

Six sessions, mapped and timed, to run all 50 FIRSTS as a live workshop

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Session Plan

Stage Eight • Soft Skills

OVERVIEW

Stage Eight's fifty FIRSTS are split across six sessions, one per section: Communication & Listening, Emotional Intelligence & Self-Awareness, Feedback & Conflict Resolution, Teamwork & Collaboration, Networking & Public Speaking, and Growth Mindset & Resilience.

Several sessions in this stage involve real interpersonal practice — role-played mediation, real feedback exchanges, real networking conversations — not just individual reflection. A cohort of people who know each other at least somewhat is genuinely preferable for this stage; several exercises land poorly with total strangers who have no real shared context to practice on.

This stage also asks more of participants emotionally than most others in the program. Build in slightly more buffer time than the agendas below strictly require, especially around Sessions 2 and 3.

AT A GLANCE

Time	Segment	Format
Session 1	Communication & Listening — 8 FIRSTS	~120 min
Session 2	Emotional Intelligence & Self-Awareness — 8 FIRSTS	~130 min
Session 3	Feedback & Conflict Resolution — 8 FIRSTS	~135 min
Session 4	Teamwork & Collaboration — 9 FIRSTS	~130 min
Session 5	Networking & Public Speaking — 9 FIRSTS	~140 min
Session 6	Growth Mindset & Resilience — 8 FIRSTS	~120 min

SESSION 1

Communication & Listening

Covers: L1 Active Listening, L4 Assertive Communication, L30 Communication Style Awareness, L36 Listening Without Interrupting, L37 Body Language Awareness, L39 Inclusive Communication, L40 Empathetic Response, L49 Listening for Understanding

PRE-WORK

- No advance preparation required. This session works best with a partner participants will interact with directly — confirm pairs or small groups in advance if the cohort is large.

SESSION AGENDA

Time	Segment	Format
0:00–0:10	Welcome + framing: soft skills are trainable, not fixed traits	Full group
0:10–0:30	FIRST L1 — Active Listening: framing + real paired conversation	Pairs

0:30-0:50	FIRST L4 — Assertive Communication Practice	Solo, then pairs practice
0:50-1:10	FIRST L30 — Communication Style Awareness	Solo, then pairs check
1:10-1:15	Short break	—
1:15-1:30	FIRST L36 — Listening Without Interrupting Challenge	Pairs
1:30-1:45	FIRST L37 — Body Language Awareness Exercise	Solo, then small groups
1:45-2:00	FIRST L39 — Inclusive Communication Practice	Small groups
2:00-2:20	FIRSTS L40 + L49 — Empathetic Response + Listening for Understanding + close	Pairs

FACILITATOR NOTES

- This entire session benefits from real partners, not solo worksheet time — build pairing in from the very start rather than adding it as an afterthought.
- L36 (no interrupting) is genuinely harder than participants expect; don't be surprised if it takes longer than planned.

SESSION 2

Emotional Intelligence & Self-Awareness

Covers: L2 Empathy Reflection, L15 Emotional Awareness Reflection, L16 Patience Challenge, L21 Perspective-Taking, L29 Emotional Intelligence Practice, L43 Emotional Regulation Drill, L45 Cultural Awareness Reflection, L48 Personal Values Statement

PRE-WORK

- Ask participants to bring to mind a real, recent disagreement they can reference honestly during FIRST L2 and L21.

SESSION AGENDA

Time	Segment	Format
0:00–0:10	Welcome + framing: this session asks for real honesty, more than most	Full group
0:10–0:30	FIRST L2 — Empathy Reflection	Solo
0:30–0:50	FIRST L15 — Emotional Awareness Reflection	Solo
0:50–1:05	FIRST L16 — Patience Challenge: framing + commit to one moment this week	Solo
1:05–1:10	Short break	—
1:10–1:30	FIRST L21 — Perspective-Taking Exercise	Solo, then optional pair share
1:30–1:50	FIRST L29 — Emotional Intelligence Practice: build vocabulary	Solo
1:50–2:05	FIRST L43 — Emotional Regulation Drill	Solo
2:05–2:25	FIRST L45 — Cultural Awareness Reflection	Solo, then optional group discussion
2:25–2:45	FIRST L48 — Personal Values Statement Written + close	Solo, then full-group share (opt-in)

FACILITATOR NOTES

- This session is entirely solo reflection by design — resist the urge to force group sharing on every exercise. Offer it as opt-in, especially for L2, L21, and L48.
- L45 (Cultural Awareness) can surface genuine, sensitive territory depending on group composition; keep any group discussion optional and be ready to redirect if it strays into generalization about specific groups.

SESSION 3

Feedback & Conflict Resolution

Covers: L5 Feedback Given, L6 Feedback Received Gracefully, L3 Conflict Resolution Practice, L23 Team Conflict Debrief, L35 Conflict Mediation Role Played, L31 Team Feedback Session Facilitated, L9 Negotiation Exercise, L33 Boundary Setting

PRE-WORK

- This session involves real, direct feedback exchanges. Let participants know in advance so no one is caught off guard by the level of directness expected.

SESSION AGENDA

Time	Segment	Format
0:00–0:10	Welcome + framing: discomfort here is normal and expected, not a sign something's wrong	Full group
0:10–0:30	FIRSTS L5 + L6 — Feedback Given + Received Gracefully	Pairs, real exchange
0:30–0:50	FIRST L3 — Conflict Resolution Practice	Solo, then real conversation happens outside session
0:50–1:10	FIRST L23 — Team Conflict Debrief	Small groups
1:10–1:15	Short break	—
1:15–1:40	FIRST L35 — Conflict Mediation Role Played	Groups of 3 (two in conflict, one mediating)
1:40–2:05	FIRST L31 — Team Feedback Session Facilitated	Small groups, rotating facilitator
2:05–2:25	FIRST L9 — Negotiation Exercise	Pairs
2:25–2:40	FIRST L33 — Boundary Setting Exercise + close	Solo, then optional share

FACILITATOR NOTES

- L35's role-play needs genuine scenarios; prepare 2–3 realistic, low-stakes conflict prompts in advance rather than asking groups to invent one cold.
- This is the emotionally heaviest session in the stage. Build in the extra buffer time flagged in the Overview, and check in on the room's energy before pushing into L9 and L33.

SESSION 4

Teamwork & Collaboration

Covers: L7 Collaboration Challenge, L8 Team Role Assumed, L32 Collaborative Brainstorm, L18 Problem-Solving Discussion, L42 Group Decision Facilitated, L44 Team Role Rotation, L34 Remote/Virtual Work Adaptation, L47 Peer Recognition Shared, L19 Decision-Making Log

PRE-WORK

- No advance preparation required, though this session works best with a consistent small group (4–6 people) throughout, rather than shifting groupings each exercise.

SESSION AGENDA

Time	Segment	Format
0:00–0:10	Welcome + framing: today is genuinely collaborative, not individual reflection	Full group
0:10–0:30	FIRST L7 — Collaboration Challenge Completed: framing + assign	Small groups (ongoing)
0:30–0:45	FIRST L8 — Team Role Assumed	Small groups
0:45–1:05	FIRST L32 — Collaborative Brainstorm	Small groups
1:05–1:10	Short break	—
1:10–1:30	FIRST L18 — Problem-Solving Discussion	Small groups
1:30–1:50	FIRST L42 — Group Decision Facilitated	Small groups, rotating facilitator
1:50–2:05	FIRST L44 — Team Role Rotation Experience	Small groups
2:05–2:15	FIRST L34 — Adaptation to Remote/Virtual Work	Solo or full-group discussion
2:15–2:30	FIRSTS L47 + L19 — Peer Recognition + Decision-Making Log + close	Small groups, then solo

FACILITATOR NOTES

- Keep the same small groups (4–6 people) across the entire session — several exercises (L8, L32, L18, L42, L44) build on each other within the same team context.
- L47 (Peer Recognition) works best when it references something genuine that happened earlier in this exact session, not a generic compliment.

SESSION 5

Networking & Public Speaking

Covers: L10 Public Speaking Confidence, L11 Presentation to Mixed Audience, L12 Networking Conversation, L13 Peer Mentoring Session, L14 Mentor Interaction, L22 Networking Follow-Up, L38 Networking Event Reflection, L41 Presentation Handling Q&A, L46 Motivational Speech Practice

PRE-WORK

- Ask participants to prepare a 60–90 second topic they could speak on comfortably, for use across several exercises in this session.

SESSION AGENDA

Time	Segment	Format
0:00–0:10	Welcome + framing: speaking and networking are both trainable, uncomfortable-at-first skills	Full group
0:10–0:30	FIRST L10 — Public Speaking Confidence Drill	Small groups, each person speaks
0:30–0:50	FIRST L11 — Presentation to Mixed Audience	Solo prep, then small groups
0:50–1:05	FIRST L12 — Networking Conversation	Pairs (ideally with someone less familiar)
1:05–1:10	Short break	—
1:10–1:30	FIRSTS L13 + L14 — Peer Mentoring + Mentor Interaction	Pairs, then swap roles
1:30–1:45	FIRST L22 — Networking Follow-Up Practice	Solo
1:45–2:00	FIRST L38 — Networking Event Reflection	Solo
2:00–2:20	FIRST L41 — Presentation Handling Q&A	Small groups, rotating presenter
2:20–2:40	FIRST L46 — Motivational Speech Practice + close	Small groups, each person speaks

FACILITATOR NOTES

- This is the longest session in the stage and the most performance-heavy; consider splitting across two shorter meetings if the cohort's energy flags.
- L13 and L14 pair naturally — have participants swap roles (mentor, then mentee) with the same partner rather than finding new pairs for each.

SESSION 6

Growth Mindset & Resilience

Covers: L17 Adaptability Exercise, L20 Critical Thinking Exercise, L24 Leadership Reflection, L25 Stress Management Technique, L26 Gratitude Practice, L27 Resilience Exercise, L28 Time Management Reflection, L50 Reflection on Soft Skill Growth

PRE-WORK

- No advance preparation required. This is the stage's closing session — encourage participants to arrive with genuine openness to reflect honestly on the whole stage, not just today's content.

SESSION AGENDA

Time	Segment	Format
0:00–0:10	Welcome + framing: today closes the loop on the entire stage	Full group
0:10–0:30	FIRST L17 — Adaptability Exercise	Solo
0:30–0:50	FIRST L20 — Critical Thinking Exercise	Solo
0:50–1:10	FIRST L24 — Leadership Reflection	Solo
1:10–1:15	Short break	—
1:15–1:30	FIRST L25 — Stress Management Technique Practiced	Solo, try one live
1:30–1:40	FIRST L26 — Gratitude Practice	Solo
1:40–2:00	FIRST L27 — Resilience Exercise	Solo
2:00–2:15	FIRST L28 — Time Management Reflection	Solo
2:15–2:40	FIRST L50 — Reflection on Soft Skill Growth + stage close	Solo, then full-group close

FACILITATOR NOTES

- FIRST L50 is the capstone of the entire stage, not just this session — give it genuine room rather than rushing it if earlier segments ran long.
- Close the full stage by having each participant name one specific soft skill they've genuinely grown in, with an example, not just a general impression.
- This is a natural moment to preview Stage Nine (English Vocabulary), which shifts from applied interpersonal practice to a different kind of skill-building.